remember hoping he had been impressed by the batting of the boys from Warmbaths, now known as Bela-Bela.

Dale Steyn took four wickets as we dismissed Province once, and then again, having asked them to follow on, and I scored a quick, unbeaten 40 in the last innings as we won by nine wickets.

Confidence returned and Northerns then travelled to Port Elizabeth to play a Warriors team that included the likes of Mark Boucher and Makhaya Ntini. Dale took another five wickets as we bowled them out for 165, and I scored 124 as we posted a first-innings score of 365, laying the foundation for what turned out to be an encouraging win by eight wickets.

Meanwhile, clouds were gathering above the Proteas. Following disappointing results on tours to New Zealand and then Sri Lanka, Eric Simons had stepped down as coach, and was replaced by Ray Jennings, promoted from the A team until at least the end of the season.

The combination of my decent early season form for the Titans and the problems endured by the national side, who then set off on a brief tour of India and lost the Test series 0–1, prompted some speculation ... but, in the middle of November 2004, as far as I was concerned, the chances of me being picked for South Africa were between very low and zero.

On Thursday, 2 December 2004, the telephone rang again.

It wasn't Dave Nosworthy.

It was Haroon Lorgat, then convenor of the national selectors.

He introduced himself and said: 'AB, we would like you to open the batting for the Proteas in the first Test match against England at St George's Park in Port Elizabeth, starting in two weeks.'

I could not believe what I had heard. Haroon continued and said I had to join the squad a few days later at a training camp to be held at the High Performance Centre at the University of Pretoria.

'Is that OK?'